

The twenty numbers

The KPIs a leadership team should see every week. One page, the same page, at every level, on the same day.

By Rob Pierce, Founder of MYReSolve

You can't improve what you can't see.

Most businesses have every one of these numbers somewhere. Almost none has put two of them on the same page.

The monthly pack arrives a week after the month ended. Forty pages. Every function has its section, its own definitions and its own paragraph explaining why the month was fine. Delivery is measured against the moved date, so it is fine. Complaints are measured as closure rate, so they are fine. Cost per order is down, so that is very good. Every function is hitting its number, and the customers are leaving, and there is no page on which those two facts meet.

Meanwhile the frontline, the people who knew at half past seven what would go wrong today, have no page at all.

These twenty numbers are the ones that cannot be flattered. Each is the primary or supporting indicator from one of the twelve books of the MYReSolve Operating Playbook. They were chosen by someone who was not being measured on them, and every one

is built from what the frontline can see, not what a function wants to show. Read together, they say whether the business is doing it once, and where it is not.

Do it once, do it right. Fourteen of the twenty count the second time: the repeat contact, the rebooked delivery, the complaint that climbed, the order touched twice. The rest count what the customer and your own people did next.

Twenty is the full set. You will not run all twenty in month one, and you should not try. Pick the three that matter most to your operation this quarter, put them on a wall the team can see and a page the board gets on the same day, and add the next one next month. Any more than a page is a pack.

How to use this page

1. **Pick three.** Start with the book whose pattern you recognise most. Its primary indicator goes first.
2. **Agree the definition once.** Written down, in the customer's terms, not the function's. "Delivered on the first promise" means the first date the customer was given, not the date the operation moved it to.
3. **Set Acceptable and Target.** Then let the Current value be what it is. The true bad number, early, is what the page is for.
4. **Same page, three levels, same day.** Frontline wall, manager's desk, executive's inbox. Same numbers, same definitions, same date. No narrative.
5. **A decision next to every number.** If a number needs explaining, the explanation is a decision, and it goes next to the number. Most of them should not be the executive's.

A The customer's numbers

What the customer was promised, whether it held, and what they did next. **It's all about the customer.**

- 01 Delivered on the first promise** PRIMARY

The share of deliveries that arrived on the first date the customer was given. Not the date the operation moved it to.

Why it can't be flattered: measuring against the moved date makes every late delivery on time. A moved date is the same delivery done twice, on your budget.

BOOK FIVE · DELIVERY PERFORMANCE
- 02 Told before it failed** SUPPORTING

Of the promises that did not hold, the share where the customer heard from you before they had to ask.

Why it matters: the rebook is often the last time a customer hears from you. Listen, in reverse: the frontline saw it at eight, and the customer should know by nine.

BOOK FIVE · DELIVERY PERFORMANCE
- 03 Came back after a problem** PRIMARY

Customers who had a problem and bought again, and the revenue they brought. The profit centre, counted.

Why it can't be flattered: refund rate down looks good on the returns page. This is the number that says whether aftersales is a cost centre or the start of the next sale.

BOOK SEVEN · AFTERSALES AND RETURNS
- 04 Retention of customers who had a problem, against those who did not** PRIMARY

Two retention rates, side by side: customers who raised a problem this year, and customers who did not.

Why it matters: if recovered customers stay as well as untroubled ones, recovery is working. If they stay better, it is working extremely well. If they leave, the recovery is a refund with an apology attached.

BOOK ONE · RECOVER
- 05 Referrals, reviews and repeat purchase** PRIMARY

Three counts on one line: customers referred by a customer, reviews left, and customers who bought again. Watch for colleagues named by name.

Why it matters: this is N+1 showing up in the numbers. The +1 cannot be scripted, so this is the only way to see whether people feel trusted enough to add it.

BOOK ONE · N+1
- 06 The promise held through peak** PRIMARY

Number 01, measured through the peak weeks only, against the same weeks last year.

Why it can't be flattered: a peak plan is every decision you will not have time to make in December, made in September. This number says whether it was. **Guard rails, not handcuffs**, set in advance.

BOOK TEN · PEAK PLANNING

B Doing it once

The cost-of-failure numbers. Each one counts the second time: the repeat, the escalation, the re-touch, the workaround. **Do it once, do it right.**

07

Resolved by the first person PRIMARY

The share of customer problems resolved by the first person who heard about them, with no handoff and no "let me check". Also known as first-contact resolution.

Why it can't be flattered: the person closest to the customer almost always knows the right answer. When this number is low it is not a skills gap, it is an authority gap. People quote the rule book because they have no choice to resolve.

BOOK TWO · ESCALATIONS AND COMPLAINTS · ALSO BOOK ONE (EMPOWERMENT) AND BOOK ELEVEN

08

Repeat contact rate for the same issue PRIMARY

Of all contacts, the share that are a customer coming back about something you already dealt with.

Why it matters: poor listening shows up here first. The first person solved the wrong problem, and the customer has to explain it again. A handling-time target pays people to make this number worse.

BOOK ONE · LISTEN

09

Time to resolved SUPPORTING

From the customer first raising it to the customer agreeing it is fixed. Measured in the customer's clock, not the ticket's.

Why it matters: a problem solved by an empowered agent is one contact and minutes. The same problem sent up the chain is four contacts, days, and a cost that climbs with every handoff.

BOOK TWO · ESCALATIONS AND COMPLAINTS · BOOK ONE (RECOVER)

10

Resolved once, in one place PRIMARY

Where a partner is involved, the share of problems settled by whoever heard them first, without the customer being passed between you and the partner. Count the times the customer told the story.

Why it can't be flattered: the customer has one contract, with you. Handing a partner the bible and saying "stick to it" is handcuffs across the company boundary, and the frustration lands as your brand.

BOOK EIGHT · OUTSOURCED AND THIRD-PARTY PARTNERS

11

Shipped clean on the day due PRIMARY

Orders that left the building on the day they were due, complete, undamaged and right first time. Count the ones touched twice.

Why it can't be flattered: units per hour says busy. This says whether the building is full or untidy. Flow starts with a standard: everything has a place, and everyone can see whether it is in it.

BOOK SIX · WAREHOUSE FLOW AND CAPACITY

12

Raised and closed the same day PRIMARY

Of the things the frontline raised today, the share that had a decision by the end of today. Count what carried over.

Why it matters: a rhythm is a set of decisions with a time attached, not a set of meetings. The frontline sees the problem first, the manager at eleven, the executive on Monday. This number is the speed of the paragraph.

13 Workarounds counted **SUPPORTING**

The number of live workarounds, spreadsheets beside the system and steps done off-process, counted honestly by the people doing them.

Why it matters: a system is a process written down so firmly nobody can bend it. Every workaround is a judgement the system was built to replace. **Behaviour, not process**, is how you halve the next change.

BOOK ELEVEN · SYSTEMS CHANGE WITHOUT CHAOS

14 Cost of failure, fully loaded **PRIMARY**

The fully loaded cost of one customer contact, multiplied by every repeat contact and escalation this month, plus the value of the customers who left after a problem. One number, this month against last.

Why it can't be flattered: cost per order down is the most expensive saving a business can make if it was bought by cutting the first attempt. This is the largest cost in the operation and the one nobody counts. The cost of the +1 against the cost of failure.

BOOK NINE · COST OF FAILURE · BOOK ONE (CHAPTER 5)

GROUP THREE

C Your own people

Happiness shows up in your own people's numbers long before it shows up in the customer's. Ethics shows up last, and moves everything.

15 First-year retention of frontline colleagues **PRIMARY**

Of the people who joined the frontline twelve months ago, the share still here. Track time to trusted alongside it.

Why it can't be flattered: two people from the same intake, one trusted by week three and one still asking permission at month six. The seven behaviours are a hiring standard, and this is whether you are keeping the people who meet it.

BOOK THREE · RECRUITING AND KEEPING FRONTLINE PEOPLE

16 Colleague retention **PRIMARY**

Retention across the whole team, with absence and engagement alongside, and the count of internal problems raised and actually solved.

Why it matters: the customer experience is the employee experience, leaking outward. Happy teams stay, and they speak up. A team that raises nothing is not a team with no problems.

BOOK ONE · HAPPINESS

17 De-escalation rate **PRIMARY**

How often a heated contact ends calmly. Count the thank-yous that arrive out of complaints.

Why it matters: "sorry for any inconvenience" is a label read off a card. Until someone senior puts it in writing that a real sorry is not an admission of liability, this number will not move.

BOOK ONE · EMPATHISE

18

Complaint themes over time PRIMARY

Not the count of complaints, the themes, and whether the same ones recur month after month. Alongside it: whether concerns get raised inside the business at all.

Why it can't be flattered: closure rate makes every complaint a success. Themes say whether you fixed the cause or the ticket. It is the slowest signal on this page, and the one that says whether the standard applies at the top.

BOOK ONE · ETHICS

GROUP FOUR

D The page itself

The only two numbers in the set that measure the reporting rather than the operation. **You can't improve what you can't see.**

19

Decisions taken from the page PRIMARY

The share of numbers on the page that had a decision attached this month, at any of the three levels.

Why it matters: a page that is read scores nothing. A page that is used scores most of its rows. When the same decision reaches the executive twice, it should go back down as authority.

BOOK TWELVE · REPORTING THAT LEADERS ACT ON

20

The age of the number SUPPORTING

How old the newest number on the page was when the executive read it.

Why it matters: the same day is the aim. A week is a pack. A month is a review. What the frontline raised at eight should be seen at the top by ten.

BOOK FOUR · DAILY OPERATING RHYTHM · BOOK TWELVE

One page. Copy it. Do not design a better one.

Every column you add is a reason for someone to stop reading. Fill in the three you are starting with. Leave the rest until next month.

MEASURE	CURRENT	ACCEPTABLE	TARGET	DECISION, AND WHOSE
A The customer's numbers				
01	Delivered on the first promise			
02	Told before it failed			
03	Came back after a problem			
04	Retention after a problem vs no problem			
05	Referrals, reviews and repeat purchase			
06	The promise held through peak			
B Doing it once				
07	Resolved by the first person			
08	Repeat contact rate for the same issue			
09	Time to resolved			
10	Resolved once, in one place			
11	Shipped clean on the day due			
12	Raised and closed the same day			
13	Workarounds counted			
14	Cost of failure, fully loaded			
C Your own people				
15	First-year retention of frontline colleagues			
16	Colleague retention			
17	De-escalation rate			
18	Complaint themes over time			
D The page itself				
19	Decisions taken from the page			
20	The age of the number			

Cost of failure, this month _____ Last month _____

Underneath, one line, because this page only needs one. The cost of failure, this month against last, with the numbers above it saying where it came from. That is the one sum that convinces a boardroom.

This page can tell you what to count. It cannot tell you what yours say.

Every one of these numbers lives in a different system, owned by a different function, defined a different way. The work is finding the ones you already have, agreeing what they mean, and putting them on one page that the frontline, the managers and the board all look at on the same day.

Run it yourself

Start with whichever book's page you can build this month. Put it on the wall and in front of the board on the same day, and add the next one next month. The twelve books of the MYReSolve Operating Playbook each end with their page and an honest word about the next step.

myresolve.uk/book

See what your operation shows today

The Structured Executive Assessment builds the first version of this page for you, as your Executive Decision Indicators, and shows where the gap between what the frontline sees and what the top decides is costing you most. It is free.

myresolve.uk/organisation-profile

Keep the page current without rebuilding it

MYReSolve is building a secure subscription that keeps this page: your indicators, your Acceptable and Target levels, refreshed from the systems you already report from, and the same page at every level. It is in development and not yet on sale. If you would like to hear when it is ready, register your interest.

myresolve.uk/kpis

WHERE EACH NUMBER COMES FROM

01 The Perfect Culture Playbook, the seven behaviours

02 Escalations and complaints

03 Recruiting and keeping frontline people

04 Daily operating rhythm

05 Delivery performance

06 Warehouse flow and capacity

07 Aftersales and returns

08 Outsourced and third-party partners

09 Cost of failure

10 Peak planning

11 Systems change without chaos

12 Reporting that leaders act on

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